behaviour. Widely known as the ‘Keralan Gandhi’, Kelappan twice began hunger strikes, but on each occasion was dissuaded from continuing by Gandhi himself. In response to these protests a Temple Entry Enquiry Committee was set up but concluded that allowing access to untouchables was ‘likely to cause breaches of the peace’. So the protests and petitions continued, now including a significant number of influential Nambudiris involved in the freedom struggle. Finally, on 12 November 1936, the Travancore Temple Entry Proclamation was published in the name of Maharaja Chithira Thirunal Balarama Varma declaring that ‘there should henceforth be no restriction placed on any Hindu by birth or religion on entering or worshipping at temples controlled by us and our Government’. The final barriers had at last come down in Travancore, although it was another ten years before the caste restrictions at Guruvayur were lifted by order of the Zamorin.

This chapter opened with an account of a brave woman’s self-sacrifice. The role played by women in history is as underwritten in India as anywhere, so it is only right to end with a mention of another woman of Kerala whose part in its history has only recently been publicly recognised. Her name was Velathu Lakshmikutty and she died in 2013 at the fine old age of 102 (see page 297). In 1952 she organised and led a march by women against the Manimalarkavu temple in Velur, Cochin, which – unbelievable as it seems to us today – was still requiring *avarna* women like herself to attend the Manimalarkavu pooram spring festival with breasts exposed. The protest that she led finally brought that particularly shaming form of caste discrimination to an end, although it serves as a reminder that the oppression of the powerless by the powerful is far from being a thing of the past.

Other legacies of Kerala’s unhappy dealings with caste injustice are slowly being resolved, one concerning the